SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #21 · WORK AND IDENTITY

“I am what I do for a living.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

“What do you do?” is often the first question we are asked, and the answer can quietly become who we are. A family that prized a certain career, a profession with long training, or a parent whose identity was their job can teach us to merge the two. This works while the job is going well. When the role changes, ends, or disappoints, the person underneath can feel lost.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors work. God worked in creation, and Paul tells us to work with our whole being, as for the Lord. But Scripture places identity before work. We are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, and the works come from who we are, not the other way around. We are made in God’s image and called by Him. A job is one place where we serve, but it is not the name God calls us by.

> *“For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life”* (Ephesians 2:10).

Also see

> “So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them” (Genesis 1:27).

> “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men” (Colossians 3:23).

> “But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God’s own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light” (1 Peter 2:9).

> “‘Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I set you apart and appointed you as a prophet to the nations.’” (Jeremiah 1:5).

Common self-statements

- If I am not my job, I do not know who I am.
- My title is my identity.
- When people ask what I do, that is who I am.
- If my work is ordinary, so am I.
- Without my role, I disappear.
- I only matter when I am working.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Reducing myself to a title.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that my identity is either my job or nothing.
- Mental filter: Seeing only the work part of who I am.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling empty when work changes and concluding that I am empty.

Challenging questions

- If someone asked who I am without using my job, what would I say?

- What roles, relationships, and values make up my identity besides work?
- What does God call me, and when did He call me that?
- How did my family treat work and identity?
- What do I lose if I let work define me?
- What qualities would remain if my job changed tomorrow?

Truth summary

> My work is a good thing I do, not the whole of who I am. I was made in God's image and made His workmanship in Christ before I did any job. I can do my work well and hold my title loosely.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Worldly
- Humility
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

In Christ Alone — Keith and Kristyn Getty with Alison Krauss
Security and salvation rest in Christ's life, death, and resurrection.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am what I do for a living"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I am what I do for a living." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who am I without my job?
- ☐ What do others value in me besides my work?
- ☐ What does God call me?
- ☐ What would remain if my role changed?
- ☐ What do I enjoy that has nothing to do with work?
- ☐ How can I introduce myself differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am more than my job.
- ☐ I am God's workmanship.
- ☐ My work flows from who I am, not the reverse.
- ☐ I can enjoy my work without being defined by it.
- ☐ My identity cannot be fired.
- ☐ God calls me by name, not by title.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 2:10
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ Genesis 1:27
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ 1 Peter 2:9
  "But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] More than my job: Each day, write one thing about yourself that has nothing to do with your work.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am God's workmanship, so my identity is more than my job.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Write "I am..." sentences without work. Complete ten sentences about who you are that do not mention a job.
- [ ] Introduce yourself differently. Next time you meet someone, share something about your family, faith, or interests before your job.
- [ ] Ask someone close. Ask a friend or family member what they value about you besides your work.
- [ ] Read the verse aloud. Say Ephesians 2:10 each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am what I do for a living": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Who I am beyond work
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am what I do for a living.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You made me and called me Yours before I did any work. Free me from being defined by my title. Help me work well and rest in who You say I am. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #22 · WORK AND IDENTITY

"Without a job, I'm worthless."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Losing work, retiring, being laid off, being unable to work because of illness, or caring for children at home can bring a painful sense of having no value. Many of us were taught that productive people matter and the rest do not. Society often reinforces it by asking "what do you do?" and treating the answer as status.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said that two sparrows are sold for a penny, and not one falls to the ground apart from the Father's will, and then He said we are worth more than many sparrows. God says we are precious and honored in His sight, and that He loves us. Paul says God proves His love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us. Our worth was set by Him before we earned anything, and it cannot be reduced by unemployment.

> *"Are not two sparrows sold for a penny? Yet not one of them will fall to the ground apart from the will of your Father. And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows"* (Matthew 10:29–31).

Also see

> "Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life" (Isaiah 43:4).

> "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

> "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows" (Luke 12:7).

> "What is man that You are mindful of him, or the son of man that You care for him?" (Psalm 8:4).

Common self-statements

- I contribute nothing without a paycheck.
- I am a drain on everyone.
- Everyone else is doing something and I am not.
- I have no purpose without a job.
- I am wasting my life.
- People do not respect someone who is not working.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling useless and concluding that I am worthless.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either employed and valuable or unemployed and worthless.
- Labeling: Calling myself "unemployed" as if it were a character trait.
- Disqualifying the positive: Dismissing everything I give to others because it is unpaid.

Challenging questions

- Who loved me before I held any job, and why?

- What do I give to people that is not paid?
- If a friend lost a job, would I say they were worthless?
- What does God say about my worth during this season?
- What do I do each day that matters, even if small?
- Who needs me, and for what?

Truth summary

> My worth was settled by God's love before I worked and will remain when I am not working. A job is a place to serve and provide, but it is not what makes me valuable. In a season without work I can still be loved, still be useful, and still be who God made me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Occupation/Job/Work
- Love, By God
- Hopeless
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Without a job, I'm worthless"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Without a job, I'm worthless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who loved me before I had a job?
- ☐ What do I give that is not paid?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend in my place?
- ☐ What does God say about my worth?
- ☐ What is one small thing I can do today?
- ☐ Who can I talk with about how I feel?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am worth more than many sparrows.
- ☐ God's love does not depend on my paycheck.
- ☐ I am valuable in every season.
- ☐ I give in ways no payroll counts.
- ☐ A job loss is a loss, not a verdict.
- ☐ I can serve and be loved without earning it.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Matthew 10:29–31**
  "Are not two sparrows sold for a penny? Yet not one of them will fall to the ground apart from the will of your Father. And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows."
- ☐ **Isaiah 43:4**
  "Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life."
- ☐ **Romans 5:8**
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I still give: Each day, write one thing you gave or did for someone that has nothing to do with pay.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Matthew 10:31 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am worth more than many sparrows, with or without a job.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Make a "worth is settled" card. Write Matthew 10:31 on a card and carry it.
- [ ] List what you give. Write down ways you help family, friends, church, or neighbors.
- [ ] Tell a trusted person how you feel. Share the heaviness of this season with someone who can listen.
- [ ] Take a practical step. Reach out to one person or resource about work options this week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Without a job, I'm worthless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Without a job, I'm worthless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You love me apart from anything I produce. When I feel worthless without a job, remind me that You value me. Guide my next step and let me rest in Your love today. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #23 · WORK AND IDENTITY

"Rest must be earned."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many of us grew up where rest was a reward for finishing everything, and the list never ended. Parents who worked without pause, jobs that praised overwork, or cultures that treat busyness as virtue can teach that rest is for people who have done enough. The result is guilt in every quiet moment and bodies that run on empty.

What Scripture teaches

God rested on the seventh day, not because He was tired but to set a pattern for us. The Sabbath command says six days we labor and on the seventh we rest. The psalmist says it is in vain to rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread, for He gives sleep to His beloved. Jesus invited His disciples to come away to a solitary place and rest for a while, and He said, "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest." Rest is a gift God gives and a command He gives, not a prize we win.

> *"And He said to them, 'Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.' For many people were coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat"* (Mark 6:31).

Also see

> "Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the LORD your God, on which you must not do any work—neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your manservant or maidservant or livestock, nor the foreigner within your gates" (Exodus 20:9–10).

> "In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved" (Psalm 127:2).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28).

> "And by the seventh day God had finished the work He had been doing; so on that day He rested from all His work" (Genesis 2:2).

Common self-statements

- I have not done enough to rest.
- If I stop, everything will fall apart.
- Rest is for lazy people.
- I feel guilty when I sit down.
- I will rest when everything is finished.
- Others are working while I rest.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should always be productive.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that rest is wrong.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I either work constantly or I am lazy.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that if I rest, things will collapse.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that rest must be earned?
- What would actually happen if I took a real rest this week?
- What does God's own example of resting say to me?
- What is rest costing me when I refuse it?
- What does rest look like for me, such as sleep, a walk, a Sabbath, or time with friends?
- What could I let go of for one day?

Truth summary

> Rest is part of God's design for me, not a reward for finishing. He gives sleep to His beloved and invites the weary to come to Him. I can rest without guilt, trusting Him with what is not done.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Tired
- Sleep Problems
- Peace
- Anxiety/Worry
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Rest must be earned"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Rest must be earned." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me that rest must be earned?
- ☐ What would happen if I rested?
- ☐ What can wait?
- ☐ What does rest look like for me?
- ☐ How does guilt show up?
- ☐ What would it mean to trust God with the unfinished list?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Rest is a gift and a command.
- ☐ God rested and calls me to rest.
- ☐ The list will never be finished.
- ☐ I can rest and still be responsible.
- ☐ He gives sleep to His beloved.
- ☐ Rest is part of faithful work.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 6:31
  "And He said to them, 'Come with Me privately to a solitary place, and let us rest for a while.' For many people were coming and going, and they did not even have time to eat."
- ☐ Psalm 127:2
  "In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for bread to eat— for He gives sleep to His beloved."
- ☐ Matthew 11:28
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Rest and guilt: Each day, write what rest you took and how strong the guilt was from 0 to 10.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Mark 6:31 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus invites me to rest, so I can rest without guilt.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Tired" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Schedule a weekly rest. Choose a block of time when you will not work and protect it.
- ☐ Take one short rest daily. Ten minutes of quiet, prayer, or a walk, without a screen.
- ☐ Name what can wait. Write what truly has to be done this week and what can wait.
- ☐ Pray with Matthew 11:28. Ask Jesus for rest and read the verse slowly.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Rest must be earned": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A rest taken
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Rest must be earned.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You invite the weary to come and rest. Forgive me for believing I must earn it. Teach me to rest without guilt and to trust You with what I cannot finish. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #24 · WORK AND IDENTITY

“My value depends on how much I earn.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When salary becomes the scoreboard, a raise feels like approval and a pay cut feels like a demotion of the self. This can come from families who compared incomes, workplaces that publicly ranked pay, or a culture that treats earnings as a measure of success. It can also arise from real need: when money is tight, earning more can feel like the only path to safety, and we slip from “I need more” to “I am worth more.”

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that we were redeemed not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ. The price of our worth has already been paid in the highest currency there is. The psalmist marvels that God is mindful of us and cares for us. We are told that we are worth more than many sparrows. A paycheck pays for work. It does not tell us who we are.

> *“For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life you inherited from your forefathers, but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot”* (1 Peter 1:18–19).

Also see

> “What is man that You are mindful of him, or the son of man that You care for him?” (Psalm 8:4).

> “And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows” (Luke 12:7).

> “Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life” (Isaiah 43:4).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

Common self-statements

- The more I earn, the more I matter.
- If someone earns more than me, they are worth more.
- My salary is my report card.
- I have to keep climbing to be worth anything.
- Making less means being less.
- People respect me for my income.

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Measuring my value against other people’s pay.
- Labeling: Treating a number as my identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either a high earner and successful or low and a failure.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling small when the number is small and concluding that I am small.

Challenging questions

- What would I say to a friend who believed this?
- What did God pay for me, and what does that say about my value?
- Whose pay do I compare mine to, and why?
- What do I need to earn for security, and what part is about status?
- What things do I contribute that no salary measures?
- What would change if my worth were already settled?

Truth summary

> My salary measures the market's price for a task, not God's price for me. I was redeemed with the precious blood of Christ. I can pursue fair pay and wise provision without making the number my worth.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money
- Worldly
- Riches, Beware of
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My value depends on how much I earn"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My value depends on how much I earn." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose income do I compare mine to?
- ☐ What do I need versus what do I want for status?
- ☐ What did Christ pay for me?
- ☐ What do I give that is not paid?
- ☐ What would change if my worth were settled?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth was paid for by Christ.
- ☐ My salary is not my value.
- ☐ I can seek fair pay without needing it for identity.
- ☐ Comparison steals contentment.
- ☐ I contribute in ways no paycheck measures.
- ☐ I am loved at every income level.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Peter 1:18–19
  "For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life you inherited from your forefathers, but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot."
- ☐ Luke 12:7
  "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows."
- ☐ Isaiah 43:4
  "Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Number and worth: Each week, write your biggest money thought and a sentence that separates the number from your worth.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Peter 1:18–19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ paid for me, so my worth is not set by my salary.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Write two columns. On one side list what you need to earn for security. On the other list what you feel you need for status.
- ☐ Limit comparisons. Avoid checking what others earn this week and notice how you feel.
- ☐ Name your contributions. List five things you give that no one pays you for.
- ☐ Memorize 1 Peter 1:18–19. Read it aloud each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My value depends on how much I earn": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth, not salary
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My value depends on how much I earn.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You paid a price for me that no salary could match. Free me from measuring myself by income. Help me work well, provide wisely, and rest in the value You have given me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #25 · WORK AND IDENTITY

“If I lose this job, I lose everything.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

When a household depends on one income, or when a job has also given us our identity, friends, and purpose, the thought of losing it can feel like the end. Past layoffs, an unstable family history, or a workplace that keeps people anxious can add to the fear. Some of the risk is real, and planning is wise, but the belief that we would lose everything can drive anxiety and poor decisions now.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not pretend that loss cannot come. But Paul writes that nothing in all creation, neither death nor life, nor the present nor the future, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus. God says do not fear, for I am with you; I will strengthen you and help you. The psalmist says that though a righteous person falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the Lord is holding his hand. A job can be lost. Our standing with God, our family, and our faith cannot.

> *“For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord”* (Romans 8:38–39).

Also see

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand” (Psalm 37:24).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things will be added unto you” (Matthew 6:33).

Common self-statements

- If this job ends, my life is over.
- I would lose my home, my friends, and my future.
- I cannot take any risk at work.
- I must say yes to everything to stay safe.
- There is nothing else for me out there.
- I would be nothing.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Jumping from job loss to total ruin.
- Fortune telling: Predicting disaster before anything has happened.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I either keep this job or lose everything.
- Overlooking resources: Forgetting the skills, people, and options I have.

Challenging questions

- What exactly would I lose, and what would I still have?
- What skills, experience, and relationships would I keep?
- Have I faced job uncertainty before, and what happened?
- What is my plan if the worst occurred, even in outline?
- What can I do now to be a little more prepared?
- What can never be taken from me?

Truth summary

> A job loss would be hard, but it would not be the loss of everything. God, my family, my faith, and my abilities would remain. I can plan wisely and prepare without letting fear run my life.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Occupation/Job/Work
- Trust
- Refuge/Safety
- Plans

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Whom Shall I Fear — Chris Tomlin
God's presence provides courage without requiring a life free of difficulty.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I lose this job, I lose everything"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I lose this job, I lose everything." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly would I lose?
- ☐ What would I keep?
- ☐ What skills and people do I have?
- ☐ What is one preparation step?
- ☐ What has God done in past uncertainty?
- ☐ What can never be taken from me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Nothing can separate me from God's love.
- ☐ A job loss is a hard event, not the end of my life.
- ☐ I have skills and people that stay with me.
- ☐ God holds my hand when I fall.
- ☐ Planning is wise; panic is not.
- ☐ I can take one preparation step now.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 8:38–39**
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."
- ☐ **Isaiah 41:10**
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ **Psalm 37:24**
  "Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
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- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I would still have: Each week, write what you would keep if the job ended and one preparation step you took.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:38–39 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Nothing can separate me from God's love, so a job loss would not be the loss of everything.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] List what cannot be lost. Write faith, family, skills, character, and experience.
- [ ] Make a basic plan. Write a simple what-if plan: who you would call, what you would update, and what you would cut first.
- [ ] Update your resume or contacts. Do one small preparation step this month.
- [ ] Pray Romans 8:38–39. Read it aloud and name your fear to God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I lose this job, I lose everything": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A preparation step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I lose this job, I lose everything.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know my fear about losing this job. Hold me, remind me that nothing can separate me from Your love, and help me plan with wisdom instead of panic. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.